

Choose the right pawn break

Positional Judgment

THE IDEA

A pawn break is often the main strategic lever in a closed position. Choose one that opens lines for your better-placed pieces or attacks an overextended chain. Prepare it so the resulting captures do not create a worse weakness.

WORKED EXAMPLE

If your rooks are aimed at the kingside and your king is secure, an f-pawn break may open useful files. If your pieces are aimed elsewhere, the same push can merely weaken your shelter and leave a pawn exposed.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What determines the timing of a break?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Piece readiness, the opponent's counterplay, and the forced capture sequence. A break becomes stronger when your pieces already occupy the lines it is about to open.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Prepare pieces for the position after the pawns move.